muted this expression of confidence by noting that this issue would remain uncertain for twenty-four to forty-eight hours, while PLO leaders reviewed his latest proposal and efforts were made to locate Arab countries willing to accept the PLO leaders and combatants. “Ambassador Habib, with all his energy and good will, did not know whether the P.L.O. is truly serious or not and indicated that he had not yet established satisfactory destinations” for the Palestinian leaders, Begin wrote. “This is the real situation today on Aug. 5 at the time of my writing to you at the end of a 45 day period which were at the disposal of Ambassador Habib to conclude the negotiations aimed at evacuating the terrorist organizations from Beirut and Lebanon which, Mr. President, is your resolve. The security of Israel and the lives of its citizens are at stake.”

Once again Begin had told me, in effect, to mind my own business.

Over the next few days, Habib’s reports from Beirut still gave me some hope that his tireless negotiations would pay off, despite mounting attacks by Israel that were taking an increasing death toll among the women and children of Beirut. On August 9, Ariel Sharon sent me a cable asking if he could come to Washington the next day to meet on the crisis. He apparently wanted to defend the attack. George Shultz cabled Sharon a message saying that I would not meet with him because I didn’t want to undercut Habib, and that Sharon should do his talking with Shultz. The following day, Shimon Peres, the leader of the Israeli opposition, came to the Oval Office for a meeting. I found him less combative and much more reasonable than Begin. He agreed that the Israeli-Arab conflict would never be settled without terms agreeable to all sides regarding political autonomy for the Palestinians and, unlike Begin, he encouraged us to continue befriending Jordan and other moderate Arab states in hopes they could help resolve the Arab-Israeli conflict.